

JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category : Cyber Safety & Digital Security

Module 5 - Online Scams

Module Overview

This handbook is your complete, beginner-to-advanced guide to **Online Scams** — covering Phishing, Vishing, Smishing, and Fake Job scams. These four scam types account for the overwhelming majority of everyday cybercrime complaints in India, and they all share one thing in common: they don't need to break your device, only your judgement in a rushed moment. This handbook trains that judgement.

By the end of this module, you will not need to search anywhere else to recognise and stop these scams before they cost you anything.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Define phishing, vishing, smishing, and fake job scams clearly
- Recognise the psychological tricks — urgency, fear, greed, authority — common to all online scams
- Spot fake websites, fake calls, fake messages, and fake job offers
- Understand why "pay first, get more later" task scams work so well
- Apply a simple verification habit before reacting to any unexpected message or call
- Know exactly where and how to report a scam in India

Why This Topic Matters

CERT-In's threat-monitoring systems identified over **128 million phishing domains** within 2.2 billion malicious DNS queries analysed in a recent year — and CERT-In itself handled **29.44 lakh cyber incidents in 2025 alone**, a 44% jump over 2024.

> *Reality Check: A 2025 survey found that 42% of WhatsApp users in India had received fraudulent job-offer messages asking for upfront payment, and 12% had experienced someone impersonating them to scam their own contacts.*

Scammers don't need to be technical geniuses. Phishing, vishing, smishing, and fake job scams all succeed the same way — by creating a moment of panic, excitement, or trust strong enough that you stop double-checking. Learning to recognise that moment is the single best protection you can build.

Introduction

All four scam types in this module are forms of **social engineering** — manipulating people psychologically rather than hacking technology.

- **Phishing** — fraud via fake emails or websites impersonating a trusted organisation

- **Vishing** — voice call ("phone") phishing, typically impersonating a bank, police, or courier official
- **Smishing** — SMS-based phishing, using fake links about deliveries, KYC, or bills
- **Fake Job Scams** — fraudulent job or task offers designed to extract money or personal data, often after building trust with small early payments

Each uses a different channel, but the underlying playbook — a trigger, a fake authority, an urgent ask — is identical.

Fundamental Concepts

The Four Channels Compared

Scam Type	Channel	Typical Disguise
Phishing	Email / fake website	Bank, government portal, e-commerce site
Vishing	Phone/video call	Police, bank official, courier, "digital arrest"
Smishing	SMS/text message	Delivery failure, KYC update, electricity bill
Fake Job Scam	WhatsApp/Telegram/SMS/social media	Recruiter, HR manager, "task-based earning" platform

The Psychological Triggers Scammers Use

Trigger	How It's Used
Urgency	"Your account will be blocked in 2 hours"
Fear	"You are under investigation" (digital arrest)
Greed	"Earn ₹5,000/day doing simple tasks"
Trust/Authority	Impersonating police, bank staff, or a well-known company
Curiosity	"You have a pending parcel/refund — click to view"

Every scam in this module uses at least one of these five triggers to stop you from pausing to verify.

Complete Detailed Explanation

Part A — Phishing

Definition: Phishing is fraud conducted through fake emails or websites designed to look like a trusted organisation, tricking victims into entering passwords, card details, or personal information.

How it works: A fake email or pop-up mimics a real brand's design almost perfectly, linking to a look-alike website (e.g., `yourbank-secure-login.com` instead of the real domain) that captures whatever you type.

How to spot it: Check the sender's actual email address (not just the display name), hover over links before clicking, and look for subtle misspellings in the domain name.

Part B — Vishing

Definition: Vishing is phishing conducted over a phone or video call, where a scammer impersonates a bank official, police officer, or other authority to extract money or information.

Common Indian patterns: Fake "digital arrest" video calls claiming you're under investigation; call-merge fraud that connects you to your bank's real OTP line while recording the OTP; fake customer-care numbers found via casual internet searches.

How to spot it: No genuine bank, police officer, or government agency will ever ask for an OTP, conduct an "arrest" over video call, or demand instant payment to avoid legal action.

Part C — Smishing

Definition: Smishing is phishing conducted through SMS or messaging apps, typically using a fake link about a delivery, KYC update, or unpaid bill.

Common Indian patterns: "Your parcel could not be delivered, pay ₹25 re-delivery fee" links; "Your SIM/KYC will be deactivated today" messages; fake electricity-disconnection texts.

How to spot it: Genuine delivery, telecom, and utility companies do not typically ask for small "fees" via unsolicited text links — verify directly through the official app or website instead.

Part D — Fake Job Scams

Definition: Fake job scams offer fraudulent employment or "easy task" earning opportunities — usually via WhatsApp, Telegram, or SMS — designed to extract upfront fees, personal data, or lure victims into larger financial fraud.

How it works — the "task scam" pattern:

1. An unsolicited message offers simple work (rating products, liking videos, "optimising" listings)
2. The victim completes a few tasks and receives a small real payment — building trust
3. The "job" then requires the victim to deposit their own money to "unlock" bigger tasks or withdraw earnings
4. Once a larger sum is deposited, the scammer disappears, or pushes the victim into a fraudulent crypto/investment platform

This "pay you first" structure is deliberately designed to disable the scepticism most people reserve for scams that ask for money upfront.

Real employers never ask candidates to pay registration fees, buy equipment, or "unlock" earnings before being paid.

Important Terminologies

Term	Simple Meaning
Phishing	Fraud via fake emails/websites impersonating a trusted organisation
Vishing	Phishing conducted via phone or video call
Smishing	Phishing conducted via SMS/text message
Task Scam	A fake job/earning scheme that pays small amounts first to build trust
Social Engineering	Psychological manipulation used to bypass normal caution
Spoofing	Disguising a caller ID, email address, or website to look genuine
Digital Arrest	A fake "arrest" conducted over video call by scammers impersonating police/officials
Look-Alike Domain	A fake website URL designed to closely resemble a real one

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Step-by-Step Understanding

How a Typical Online Scam Unfolds

1. **Contact** — You receive an unexpected email, call, SMS, or job offer
2. **Trigger** — A psychological trigger (urgency, fear, greed, trust) is applied
3. **Ask** — You're asked to click a link, share an OTP, or pay a small fee
4. **Escalation** — Trust is built (small payout, convincing script) before a bigger ask
5. **Loss** — Money or data is taken, and contact typically goes silent afterward

How to Verify Before You React (Step-by-Step)

1. Pause — no genuine deadline requires an instant, panicked response
2. Identify the organisation being impersonated
3. Go directly to their official app or website — never use a link/number from the message itself
4. Confirm with them directly whether the communication is genuine
5. Report the message/call/offer if it turns out to be fraudulent

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Real-Life Indian Examples

(Widely reported public incidents, described for educational awareness.)

- **Bengaluru WhatsApp Task Scam (2026):** A software engineer lost approximately ₹43.48 lakh after a WhatsApp part-time job offer involving fake product ratings evolved into a fraudulent cryptocurrency investment through a counterfeit exchange link.

- **Karnataka Task-Fraud Cases (2026):** State data recorded 395 task-fraud cases in the year so far, with a meaningful share involving cryptocurrency-based schemes — reflecting how fast this scam category is growing.
- **WhatsApp Impersonation Scams:** A 2025 survey found that 12% of respondents had experienced someone impersonating them on WhatsApp to scam their own contacts, showing how phishing/smishing tactics increasingly exploit existing personal networks.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario 1: You get an email that looks exactly like it's from your bank, asking you to "verify your account" by clicking a link.
Don't click. Open your bank's app or type its official website address directly to check for any real notifications.

Scenario 2: A WhatsApp message offers ₹500 for "liking 5 YouTube videos," and after completing them, you're asked to deposit ₹2,000 to "unlock higher-paying tasks."
This is a task scam. No legitimate job asks you to pay to access more work or earnings.

Scenario 3: You receive an SMS that your bank KYC will expire today unless you click a link and re-verify.
This is smishing. Visit your bank's branch or official app directly — banks don't deactivate accounts via unsolicited text links.

Scenario 4: A caller claiming to be from the "cyber crime cell" says a parcel with illegal items was booked in your name and you must stay on a video call to avoid arrest.
This is vishing (a digital arrest scam). Disconnect immediately — no Indian agency arrests or investigates over a call.

Government Rules / Guidelines

- **CERT-In:** India's national cyber incident response agency, which analyses billions of DNS queries to identify malicious and phishing domains, and issued the CISG-2025-02 guidelines (effective 25 July 2025) mandating annual third-party cybersecurity audits for many digital entities.
- **Cyber Swachhta Kendra:** A CERT-In initiative providing free malware-removal tools to citizens, with coverage reported across roughly 98% of India's digital population.
- **I4C (Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre):** Coordinates the national response to cybercrime, including phishing, vishing, smishing, and job-fraud complaints, under the Ministry of Home Affairs.

Laws & Policies

Law / Provision	What It Covers
IT Act, 2000 — Section 66C	Punishes identity theft, including impersonation used in phishing/vishing/smishing
IT Act, 2000 — Section 66D	Punishes cheating by impersonation using a computer resource — the core offence in most online scams
IT Act, 2000 — Section 66	Covers broader computer-related offences, including unauthorised access resulting from phishing
Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023	Applies alongside the IT Act for cheating and fraud offences committed through digital means, including fake job scams
CERT-In CISG-2025-02 Guidelines (2025)	Mandates annual third-party cybersecurity audits and structured breach reporting to reduce large-scale phishing infrastructure

Important Statistics

Metric	Figure
Phishing domains identified by CERT-In's monitoring systems	Over 128 million (within 2.2 billion malicious DNS queries analysed)
CERT-In cyber incidents handled (2025)	29.44 lakh, up about 44% from 20.41 lakh in 2024
CERT-In security alerts/advisories issued (2025)	1,530 alerts, 390 vulnerability notes, 65 advisories
WhatsApp users in India who received fake job-offer messages (2025 survey)	42%
Users who experienced WhatsApp impersonation of themselves	12%
Cyber Swachhta Kendra digital population coverage	About 98%
Overall reported cybercrime losses in India (2025)	Approximately ₹22,495 crore

(Figures are approximate, drawn from CERT-In/PIB reports, WEF publications, and survey data through 2025–2026.)

Best Practices

- Pause before reacting to any unexpected email, call, SMS, or job offer
- Verify independently through official apps/websites — never through links or numbers in the message itself
- Never share OTPs, passwords, or personal documents based on an unsolicited request
- Treat any job offer requiring an upfront payment as fraudulent by default

- Check sender email addresses and website URLs carefully for subtle misspellings
- Report suspicious messages/calls to your service provider and to cybercrime.gov.in

Common Mistakes

- Clicking links in unexpected emails or SMS without checking the sender
- Assuming a call is genuine because the caller sounds official or knows personal details
- Paying an upfront "registration" or "unlock" fee for a job or task platform
- Trusting a website because its design looks identical to the real one
- Not verifying independently before reacting to an urgent message
- Staying on a "digital arrest" video call out of fear instead of disconnecting

Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"I can tell a phishing email by bad spelling alone"	Modern phishing emails are often well-written and visually identical to genuine ones
"A job that already paid me a little can't be a scam"	Task scams deliberately pay small amounts first specifically to build false trust
"The caller knew my name and address, so it must be genuine"	Personal details are often available through data leaks and used to make scams convincing
"Only careless or uneducated people fall for these scams"	Educated professionals and senior citizens are frequently targeted and affected
"If I stay calm and follow instructions, a 'digital arrest' call will resolve safely"	No such call is genuine — the only safe action is to disconnect immediately

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Verify unexpected messages/calls independently via official channels	Don't click links or call numbers provided within the suspicious message itself
Treat "pay to unlock earnings" job offers as fraud	Don't pay upfront fees for any job, task, or "training"
Disconnect immediately from any "digital arrest" call	Don't stay on the call or follow its instructions
Report scams to cybercrime.gov.in or 1930	Don't try to negotiate or reason with a scammer directly
Double-check sender addresses and URLs closely	Don't assume a professional-looking message is automatically genuine

Safety Tips

For Email & Web
- Hover over links to preview the actual destination before clicking
- Check the sender's full email address, not just the display name
- Use browser warnings about unsafe sites seriously — don't proceed past them

For Calls & Video Calls
- Hang up on any call demanding urgent payment or threatening arrest
- Call your bank/organisation back only via the number on their official app/card
- Never merge calls at a stranger's request

For SMS & Messaging Apps
- Don't click links in unsolicited delivery/KYC/bill messages
- Verify any "account expiry" claim directly through the official app
- Be cautious of unknown numbers offering jobs or "easy income"

For Job Hunting
- Research the company independently before engaging further
- Never pay a fee to receive, start, or "unlock" a job or task
- Be wary of recruitment conducted entirely over WhatsApp/Telegram with no formal process

Practical Checklist

- [ ] Learned to check sender addresses and URLs before clicking
- [ ] Know never to share OTP/passwords over calls, SMS, or email
- [ ] Understand the "pay small, ask big" pattern in task scams
- [ ] Know to disconnect immediately from any "digital arrest" call
- [ ]

Saved the 1930 cybercrime helpline number

☐ Discussed these scam patterns with family members

☐ Know how to file a complaint at cybercrime.gov.in

Quick Revision Notes

- Phishing = fake email/website; Vishing = fake call; Smishing = fake SMS; Fake Job Scams = fraudulent work/task offers
- All four are social engineering — they target your judgement, not just your device
- Common triggers: urgency, fear, greed, authority, curiosity
- Task scams pay small amounts first specifically to build false trust
- No genuine agency conducts arrests or investigations over a call
- Real jobs never require you to pay to receive or "unlock" work

Key Takeaways

1. Every scam in this module relies on rushing you past your own scepticism
2. A message or call being professional-looking or personalised doesn't make it genuine
3. Being paid first doesn't make a job offer legitimate — it can be exactly the trap
4. The safest response to any unexpected urgent request is to pause and verify independently
5. Reporting quickly at cybercrime.gov.in or 1930 gives you the best chance of recovery

Glossary

- **Digital Arrest** — A fake "arrest" conducted over video call by scammers impersonating officials
- **Look-Alike Domain** — A fake website URL closely resembling a genuine one
- **Phishing** — Fraud via fake emails/websites impersonating a trusted organisation
- **Similarly Smishing** — Phishing conducted via SMS/text message
- **Social Engineering** — Psychological manipulation used to bypass normal caution
- **Spoofing** — Disguising a caller ID, sender address, or website to appear genuine
- **Task Scam** — A fake job/earning scheme paying small amounts first to build trust
- **Vishing** — Phishing conducted via phone or video call

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is the difference between phishing, vishing, and smishing?
Phishing uses fake emails/websites, vishing uses phone/video calls, and smishing uses SMS/text messages — all with the same underlying goal of tricking you into sharing information or money.

2. How can I tell if a job offer is fake?
Be suspicious of unsolicited offers via WhatsApp/Telegram, requests for upfront payment, and vague or overly simple "tasks" for high pay.

3. Why do task scams pay me a little money first?
To build false trust and disable the scepticism people normally apply to requests for upfront payment.

4. Is it safe to click a link in a delivery-failure SMS?
No — verify directly through the courier's official app or website instead of clicking unsolicited links.

5. What is a "digital arrest" scam?
A fraud where scammers impersonate police/officials over video call, falsely claiming you're under investigation to pressure you into transferring money.

6. Can a phishing email look completely legitimate?
Yes — modern phishing emails are often professionally designed and visually identical to the real thing.

7. Should I ever pay to "unlock" earnings on a job platform?
No — legitimate employers never require payment to access work or receive earnings.

8. What should I check before clicking a link in an email?
Hover over it to preview the actual destination URL, and verify the sender's full email address.

9. What is spoofing?
Disguising a caller ID, email address, or website to make it appear genuine.

10. Are senior citizens more likely to be targeted by these scams?
They are frequently targeted, though these scams also affect educated professionals across all age groups.

11. What's the safest response to an urgent "your account will be blocked" message?
Pause, and verify independently through the organisation's official app or website — never react instantly.

12. Can I trust a caller who already knows my name and address?
No — personal details are often available through data leaks and used deliberately to sound convincing.

13. What is social engineering?
Psychological manipulation — using triggers like urgency, fear, or greed — to bypass a person's normal caution.

14. How do I report a phishing email or scam SMS in India?
Through the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (cybercrime.gov.in) or by calling the 1930 helpline.

15. What should I do if I already shared an OTP or clicked a suspicious link?
Contact your bank immediately to secure your account, change relevant passwords, and file a report at cybercrime.gov.in.

16. Is it normal for a "recruiter" to hire entirely over WhatsApp?
It's a red flag — legitimate hiring usually involves verifiable company channels, not exclusively informal messaging apps.

17. What does CERT-In do about phishing?
It uses AI-driven, large-scale DNS monitoring to identify malicious and phishing domains and issues advisories to reduce their impact.

18. Can scammers fake a company's entire website?
Yes — look-alike domains can closely copy a real website's design, so always check the URL carefully.

19. What if a "bank employee" asks to merge my call with someone else?
Refuse and hang up — this is a known tactic (call-merge fraud) to capture your real OTP.

20. Is a message safe just because it comes from a number saved as a company's name?
No — caller ID and sender names can be spoofed; verify independently regardless of what's displayed.

21. What's the one habit that stops most of these scams?
Pausing to verify independently through official channels before reacting to any unexpected request.

22. Where can families learn to protect elderly relatives from these scams?
By discussing these patterns directly, and pointing them to official resources like cybercrime.gov.in and the 1930 helpline.

Suggested Infographics, Flowcharts & Illustrations

(For JanGyan design team — placement suggestions only; no images generated here)

- **"Four Scam Channels" comparison icon set** → within "Fundamental Concepts"
- **Flowchart: "How a Task Scam Escalates"** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part D"
- **"Spot the Fake Email" annotated example** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part A"
- **Psychological triggers wheel (urgency/fear/greed/authority/curiosity)** → within "Fundamental Concepts"
- **"Pause and Verify" 5-second rule card** → near "Practical Checklist"

Official References

- Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In) — annual incident and advisory data, CISG-2025-02 guidelines
- Press Information Bureau (PIB), Government of India — releases on CERT-In performance and Cyber Swachhta Kendra
- World Economic Forum — Global Cybersecurity Outlook 2025 and Fighting Cyber-Enabled Fraud report (featuring CERT-In data)
- Information Technology Act, 2000 (as amended), India Code portal
- National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal — official complaint categories and guidance

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Official Government Website Links

- National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal: **https://cybercrime.gov.in**
- CERT-In: **https://www.cert-in.org.in**
- Cyber Swachhta Kendra: **https://www.csk.gov.in**
- Ministry of Home Affairs: **https://www.mha.gov.in**
- Press Information Bureau: **https://pib.gov.in**

Cybercrime Helpline (24×7, Toll-Free): 1930

Conclusion

Phishing, vishing, smishing, and fake job scams all succeed the same way — by finding the one moment you don't pause to verify. They don't need to be technically sophisticated because they're aimed at your judgement, not your device's defences. Learning the shared pattern behind all four — a trigger, a fake authority, an urgent ask — means you'll recognise the next one instantly, whatever channel it arrives through.

This is only the next step in your Cyber Safety journey with JanGyan. Stay alert, stay informed, and remember: **pause, verify independently, and never let urgency make the decision for you.**

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Module 5 of the Cyber Safety & Digital Security Category